

PAVO

THE PEACOCK

REPRESENTING THE EYE-CATCHING BIRD FROM INDIA, PAVO WAS FIRST DEPICTED ON A CELESTIAL GLOBE IN 1598. THE CONSTELLATION IS FOUND ON THE EDGE OF THE MILKY WAY, SOUTH OF TELESCOPIUM AND BETWEEN ARA AND INDUS.

Pavo is one of the 12 constellations devised by the Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman, who voyaged in the Southern Hemisphere in the late 16th century and catalogued its stars. It is in a fairly featureless area of the sky but easily spotted because of its brightest star, Alpha Pavonis. Named Peacock in the late 1930s, it marks the bird's head. Pavo's flamboyant

open tail feathers are drawn around a rectangle of stars. In the middle of this is Kappa Pavonis, a yellow supergiant, and one of the brightest Cepheid variables in the sky. Visible to the naked eye, this star varies in brightness every 9.1 days between magnitudes 3.9 and 4.8 as it expands and contracts. Pavo also contains an impressively bright globular cluster, NGC 6752, also visible to the naked eye.

KEY DATA

Size ranking

44

Brightest stars

Alpha (α)
1.9, Beta (β) 3.4

Genitive

Pavonis

Abbreviation

Pav

Highest in sky at 10pm

July–September

Fully visible

15°S–90°S



CHART 2

MAIN STARS

Peacock

Alpha (α) Pavonis

Blue-white giant

1.9

179 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 6744

Barred spiral galaxy

NGC 6752

Globular cluster

NGC 6782

Barred spiral galaxy

Peacock (α Pavonis)
A blue-white giant of magnitude 1.9; it is about 5 times the Sun's width and 2,200 times its luminosity

NGC 6782
A barred spiral galaxy with tightly wound arms; it is 180 million light-years away and is of magnitude 11.8

NGC 6752
One of the largest and brightest globular clusters in the sky; at magnitude 5.4, it is just visible with the naked eye

NGC 6744
A barred spiral galaxy lying about 30 million light-years away; it is almost face-on to Earth and can be seen with a small telescope

